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The Many Faces of Improvisation: The Arab Taqāsīm As a Musical Symbol

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The phenomenon of improvising music is generally esteemed for the artistry it entails and the aura of significance it appears to embrace. Creating music in performance is recognized as an art in its own right, but also as an expression imbued with special connotations. In this study, I argue that musical improvisation in the East-Mediterranean Arab world, for example in such major urban centers as Beirut, Damascus, Aleppo, and Cairo, enjoys a primary position because its message is symbolic as well as affective. More specifically, improvising instrumental music makes sense on both stylistic and connotative levels, and furthermore, its efficacy as a performance genre owes significantly to the idiosyncratic ways in which it evokes the social and artistic values of Arab listeners and performers.

The symbolic significance of improvisation is closely intertwined with the manner in which music in general makes symbolic sense. Ethnomusicalological writings, usually based upon broader theoretical paradigms, interpret musical symbolism in a wide variety of ways. On a fundamental level, music is considered symbolic because it is capable of denoting entities other than itself. As a form of auditory representation, music may evoke symbolic meaning through such parameters as timbre, meter, melody, textures, and musical instruments, for example when making reference to supernatural forces in the context of religious ritual (Golkammer 1982:901, 905; Shiloah 1978:56–65). Music can embrace elements of direct or indirect referentiality, thus programmatically portraying or suggesting extramusical phenomena (although often, as well, it does not do so) (Becker 1983:72). Music also embodies an element of symbolic value, particularly when connected to specific cultural ideals, for example the desire to be novel or to confirm a community's premium on individuality. As an entity that "abstracts and distills," music can be valued as a perfect expression (Nettl 1987).

Furthermore, music is deemed symbolic because it exhibits inherent compatibilities with the object it signifies. For example, its internal pattern-

ing can make it well-suited for ritual functions, which are highly patterned themselves (Herndon and McLeod 1979:112). As such, music constitutes a metaphor or a microcosm of something else. In other words, it embraces elements of "iconicity," because its internal content resonates with broader conceptual, societal, and cosmic structures, for instance in the case of gamelan music in Javanese culture (Becker and Becker 1982). In a similar vein, symbolic significance stems from the coherence between musical structure and social behavior, or from the nonarbitrary resemblance between a sign and what is signified (Turino 1989).

Meanwhile, music is thought to owe its symbolic effectiveness to its own internal design, its inherent qualities as a category of experience. Accordingly, music and other artistic expressions operate within specific "semiotic systems" whose significance extends beyond their own strict domains (Geertz 1983:109). With this interpretation in mind, numerous ethnomusicological writings have highlighted the coherences, tensions, reversals, and negotiations between music as a symbolic system and other experiential domains (see Keil 1966; Seeger 1979; Roseman 1989). In other words, music is symbolically efficacious because it is inherently musical, or because it can reflect, connote, and affect in fundamentally musical ways. I posit that music, paradoxically perhaps, gains symbolic poignancy through its ineffability as an aesthetic experience, or differently stated, because it can point toward itself, as well as suggest meanings beyond its immediate perimeters. Thus, its symbolic effectiveness appears inextricably linked to its affective message. Similarly, I demonstrate that musical significance is multifarious. Depending on the genre of performing, music can make sense in many, often disparate and seemingly contradictory ways.

Improvisation As Symbol

The ways in which musical improvisation is symbolically construed depends largely upon the cultural setting and the perceptions of individual listeners and performers. Whereas some musical milieus place a high premium upon the improvisatory process, others value precomposition, or the creation of relatively fixed compositional works. In effect, the symbolic meaning attached to improvised music may be indicative of how the process of improvising is generally interpreted, keeping in mind that in certain communities the concept of improvisation tends to conjure dubious connotations of the impromptu, the casual, the undisciplined, the unprepared, and so on. Furthermore, the symbolic efficacy of improvisatory music is influenced by the immediate contextual and emotional circumstances, the individual listener's level of musical sophistication, and the existence or lack of other conducive symbolic factors. "The effectiveness

of musical symbols depends as much on human agency and social context, as on the structure of the symbols themselves" (Blacking 1985:64). In general, the special significance of improvisation centers around the musical substance, the individual artist, the community, and life in general, as indicated by the following twelve widely shared perspectives:

1. Improvisation is considered an intuitive art. Improvising is thought to transcend the realm of explicit rationalization and to occur on a mental or psychological plateau that is difficult to fathom or explain in plain musicological terms. Like other creative musical pursuits, it appears to entail spontaneity rather than purely conscious calculation (Ghiselin, ed. 1952:15). As one researcher puts it, improvisation is "essentially nonacademic" (Bailey 1992:ix).

2. Improvisation may exist as an art of practice. Its *modi operandi* are thought to be enigmatic, thus transcending the realm of formally established music theory. Accordingly, the improviser taps into a domain of consciousness that places the improvised product above the plane of ordinary theoretical rationalization. Stating that Arab improvisatory models seem extremely elusive, Edith Gerson-Kiwi writes:

Paradoxically, the free composing and improvising along certain melodic models seemed to resist any rational typology of their grouping. Moreover, the procedure of variations developed upon a non-existent theme, while each of them contained enough thematic properties to be identified as the theme itself. (Gerson-Kiwi 1970:66)

As a variation on a theme that does not exist, or rather the creation of "a version of something" rather than "improvising upon something" (Nettl 1974:9), Arab improvisation constitutes a veritable art of practice. It is often said that improvisation is learned and perfected through failures and successes, and that it constitutes a practical art that utilizes no theoretical rules that are exclusive to it. In this sense, it is not the practice of a specific theory but, "the practice of practice" (Bailey 1992:xi).

3. Improvisation is believed to be highly creative. Producing music on the spot is deemed extraordinary in terms of the talent it requires. Those who can improvise are usually thought of as being exceptionally gifted. The improviser may be cherished because of his virtuosic playing and the exceptional skill he is capable of displaying, although, as in Chernoff's discussion of the Ewe master drummer, improvisation is expected to exhibit clarity, internal coherence, coordination with other musical components, and fundamental aesthetic sensibility. Improvisers are valued for "the complexity and movement of their improvisational organization" (Chernoff 1979:121 ff).

4. Improvisation can appear highly personal, or individualized. As a form of creativity, producing music instantaneously has an inward or pri-

vate dimension, as it enables performers “to be themselves” rather than play “compositions” by others. In other words, the artists are able to speak of musical performances as being “theirs” (Bailey 1992:11). Thus, improvisation is thought of as an ideal medium of self-expression.

5. Improvisation is linked to inspiration. The process of improvising, namely “the creation of a musical work, or the final form of a musical work, as it is being performed” (Horsley et al. 1980:31) is associated with extraordinary ability. It may be attributed to some form of genius that inspires the performers and leads them to generate superior musical renditions. Similarly, many cultures correlate the improvisatory process with transformative experiences, or altered states of consciousness, as well as with momentarily heightened aesthetic ability. Along these lines, the expression of being “out there” is used as a metaphor of creative transcendence among avant-garde jazz musicians (Such 1981:83–95). Flamenco musicians comparably use the expression *duende* to describe the magic that drives performing artists to excellence (Papenbrok 1985). One such musician also uses the idea of “letting oneself go” to depict the effortless and spontaneous process of producing highly affective musical renditions (quoted in Bailey 1992:16). Meanwhile, Iranian musicians refer to the concept of *hāl* to describe the mystical state that inspires the artist to perform haunting music, for example, at a *bazm*, or informal musical gathering. Accordingly, ‘in a state of *hāl*, the musician does things which are not necessarily planned, but just “come out” because he is not himself’ (Varzi 1986:5).

6. Improvisation is correlated with power. In several traditions, the improviser gains efficacies that are artistic, and sometimes physical and metaphysical. In medieval Islamic sources for example, we read about a certain performer who played (improvised) in a certain melodic mode, thus causing the listeners at a court assembly to laugh, then in another mode to make them cry, and yet in a third to cause them to sleep.¹ In many modern cultures, the ability to create music on the spot grants the artist a special status as a musical evocator.

7. Improvisation represents the musical idiom. In various cultures the art of improvising constitutes the most eloquent “voice” of the established musical system. Viewed as such, it is cherished and transmitted from one generation to another. As shown in the context of flamenco music, improvisers regard their art as a prime expression of the musical tradition and a vehicle for keeping the idiom alive (Bailey 1992:18). Similarly, in the case of Arab music, improvisation has been shown to combine freedom with adherence to established and somewhat predictable modal patterns (Nettl and Riddle 1973; Nettl 1974; Marcus 1993).

8. Improvisation constitutes a merger between the familiar and the novel. It is described as an appropriate balance between satisfying the

musical norm and departing from it, perhaps an intermediary between compliance and defiance. In some traditions, a successful improviser must strive both to be on the innovative or exploratory edge, as well as to preserve the authenticity of the music. As soprano saxophonist Steve Lacy puts it, the music must find its place "in between the known and the unknown" (quoted in Bailey 1992:54).

9. Improvisation tends to involve the audience directly. At improvisatory events, listeners often play a direct role as they become part of the overall improvisatory process. As "the art of performing music spontaneously without the aid of manuscript, sketches, or memory" (Apel 1972:404), improvisation often serves as a context, or at times a pretext, for group involvement, particularly when such involvement is found artistically or symbolically desirable. "As a group process, improvisation contributes to joy, establishing a dialogue with 'hip' audiences by letting all parties participate in the creative aspects of music" (Hall 1992:233). In effect, the audience can provide a conducive musical ambiance for, and also shape the content of, the performance through what can be described as "creative listening" (Racy 1991:14-17). In a more specific sense, the late Jerry Garcia of the Grateful Dead explained that in public, this rock group becomes more adventurous. The audience inspires music that is more interesting as it frees the artists to explore (Bailey 1992:46-47).

10. Improvising may generate a sense of mystical or emotional transcendence. Because of its relatively free structure, improvised music may fit well within certain social and ideological systems. For example, Lois al-Fārūqī claims that Arab music, like all other Islamic arts, centers around the religious principle of *tawhīd* or "unity," and similarly, that Arab improvised genres are valued because they comply with the model of Qur'anic chanting, a prototype established in the early Islamic epochs (1985:3-36). In a somewhat different vein, the combination of improvisatory singing and the fixed beat-pattern that accompanies it in Egyptian Sufi music is described as a metaphor for the mystical connection between the Divine and the human world. Accordingly, it connotes both freedom to express individuality and a sense of dependence (Waugh 1989:170).

11. Improvisation is associated with freedom. Accordingly, it means license to transcend musical boundaries, to defy, or at least "play around" certain norms and expectations. Because "it may involve the work's immediate composition by its performers, or the elaboration or adjustment of an existing framework, or anything in between" (Horsley:31), improvisation can be viewed as a desirable departure or even relief from the established artistic canon. As a form of interpretive flexibility, it may even enhance the aesthetic appeal of otherwise rigidly fixed musical compositions. Throughout European history, the phenomenon of playing in *tempo rubato*

(literally “robbed” or “stolen time”) which implies a certain measure of temporal freedom, has both fascinated and alarmed music critics. Projecting into the future of this phenomenon, Richard Hudson writes:

Rubato in any form is an extraordinary device. It is seldom trivial, incidental, or commonplace. It is, after all, a violation of the orderly passing of time. . . . Indeed, it measures the capacity of a performer to comprehend the inner meaning of a work of art. For the listener it projects the sense of the most expressive moments in music, and instead of injuring the precious time continuum, acts ultimately to strengthen it, enhance it, and add to it special warmth and colour. (1994:447–48)

Meanwhile, in their impromptu musical interpretations, skilled jazz musicians may take the artistic liberty of distorting or stretching out certain musical components, creating musical parodies of certain well-known tunes, and presenting different musical components in striking juxtapositions (Berliner 1994:256–59). In a comparable vein, flamenco guitarist Paco Peña explains that in his tradition the artist is “completely free,” as he plays differently from one day to another, or is totally free to improvise or not to improvise (quoted in Bailey 1992:16–17). In its extreme form, the concept of improvisatory freedom applies to the so called “free improvisation,” associated with avant-garde jazz and modern experimental music. In this case, the art of improvising is said to lack a stylistic plan or “idiomatic commitment,” merely reflecting “the sonic-musical identity of the person or persons playing it” (Bailey 1992:83). In short, musical improvisation can be seen as a form of artistic maneuvering, or skillful “play with the system” (Hall 1992:224). It is thought to manipulate rather than replicate, confound rather than conform.

12. Improvisation in music, as in other aspects of life, is considered the natural thing to do. Being intuitive and spontaneous, improvising constitutes an integral part of various creative processes (Nachmanovitch 1990:17). Shown to differ from what we call “composition” in degree rather than in essence, improvisation “releases the sudden impulse to music through the direct production of sound” (Nettl 1974:4). From a broader perspective, Edward T. Hall views it as an appropriate path toward learning or mastering skills. He describes it as a sort of magical phenomenon that entails experimentation and “play,” thus falling within the realms of creativity and expertise rather than occurring as an aimless or haphazard activity (Hall 1992:231–33). In this fashion, improvisation can be said to both imitate life and contribute to the art of living.

To sum up, the above connotative interpretations point clearly to the multi-layered significance of musical improvisation. More precisely, they enable us to reconstruct aspects of musical significance along individual thematic poles that on various conceptual levels seem quite distinct and

even oppositional, but in some ways also interrelated and complementary. From a cross-cultural perspective, the improvisatory endeavor appears to both comply and challenge, conform and confront, reflect inwardly and appeal collectively, emerge like an evanescent mist and manifest itself like a brightly demarcated landscape. In this general light, we may turn to one specific cultural model, as we investigate how such poles of significance might explain the symbolic substance of the Arab *taqāsīm*.

The Art of Taqāsīm

Historically, improvisation has occupied a prominent position in Near-Eastern music in general. Actually, many facets of the current improvisatory practice, including typical listening mannerisms, can be traced back to medieval court performances (Sawa 1981). In the modern Arab world, the ability to improvise modally is generally considered a trademark of good musicianship. Instrumental and vocal improvisations, which may be heard in combination with non-improvised compositions or alone, are known to require extraordinary skill, talent, and inspiration, and to generate deeply felt emotions within the listeners. When properly performed they are considered ecstatically moving, as well as technically sophisticated. A prime example of modal improvisation, although traditionally not considered "music" as such, is the art of *tajwīd*, or Qur'anic chanting, which is deeply revered as a sacred expression. On the whole, improvisatory genres are highly cherished, especially by the *sammī'ah* (singular, *sammī'*, from *sama'* or "listening"), namely the musical connoisseurs, or those who listen very well.

In the Arab Near-East, improvising modally on such instruments as the 'ūd, qānūn, nāy, and violin is known as *taqāsīm* (singular, *taqsīm*).² Structurally, a *taqsīm* in a specific *maqām*, or melodic mode, tends to be self-contained; it is begun, developed, and resolved in accordance with an established modal plan. As discrete renditions, *taqāsīm* can be heard on thousands of recordings from the early decades of the twentieth century, for example by celebrated Egyptian instrumentalists such as the qānūn player Muḥammad al-'Aqqād, violinist Ibrāhīm Sahlūn, nāy player Amīn al-Buzārī, and more recently, composer and 'ūd player Riyāḍ al-Sunbātī, violinist Aḥmad al-Hifnāwī, and many others. Furthermore, such *taqāsīm* renditions are typically played in intimate musical contexts, such as the *jalsah*, or informal gathering, and at times presented as somewhat separate pieces in the middle of a *ḥaflah*, or large, usually public performance event. The *taqāsīm* and other improvisatory genres may also appear within larger performance formats, such as Egypt's early twentieth-century *waṣlah* (a

type of medley, or compound-form embracing different musical genres that share the same maqām) and its traditional Syrian counterpart, the *fāṣil*.³

The Home-Base

In modern Arab cities, improvising carries a diversity of connotations. Specifically, it projects a symbolic message that is multifarious and capable of shifting from one extreme pole of significance to another. One of these poles represents the conventional, normative, stable, and shared facets of Arab culture. Musically speaking, it stands for such realms as current practice, familiarity, expectancy, correctness, shared knowledge, or in some respect collective consciousness. In the same vein, this pole encompasses the artistic threads that bond together the initiated listener, the musician, and the surrounding musical milieu, thus creating a sense of musical and social commonality, or metaphorically speaking, a feeling of a cultural and aesthetic “home-base.”

The home base component is represented in a variety of ways. For one thing, the improvisers utilize the culture’s indigenous musical idiom. To begin with, they work with musical ingredients that form the crux of the modal tradition. Their improvisations, for example, must display correct melodic intervals, including the basic microtonal steps and the finer international inflections that tend to affect the various pitch levels. Similarly expected is the proper rendering of the *qaflāt* (singular *qaflah*), or the largely stylized and highly intricate cadential patterns that end certain musical phrases. To add, the taqāsīm genre in particular is recognized as the prime “translator” of the maqāmāt (plural of maqām) as theoretical modal structures, because it is considered “purely” modal. In other words, it flows typically without the imposition of an *iqā’* (plural, *iqā’āt*), or “rhythmic mode,” and without the interference of a sung text. Furthermore, it follows relatively flexible structural tracks, without adhering to the fixed formal and melodic designs that characterize precomposed pieces. In various theory books, the *sayr*, literally “path,” or the brief description of how each mode is expected to unfold, implies that the purest realizations of the modes are textless, meterless, and nonstrophic, a stylistic profile epitomized by the taqāsīm.

Similarly, the improvisers speak their culture’s emotional language. In performance, taqāsīm players feel the *saṭṭanah*, or ecstatic content of the maqāmāt and translate their own feeling into highly affective musical performances (Racy 1983:399 and 1991:13–14). Those who feel the modes ecstatically are said to possess what Arab musicians call “Eastern soul,” a term that refers to the very core, or aesthetic essence of the indigenous

modal tradition. They are also known to have *aṣālah*, namely “genuineness,” or rootedness in the Arab modal practice. In some sense, the modal improviser is an artistic custodian whose talent enables him to gain access to the hidden affective powers of the *maqāmāt*. Recreating the musical system and giving it concrete existence through practice, he is recognized as a prime conveyor of *ṭarab*, or musical ecstasy.

As a tradition bearer, the *taqāsīm* performer must also be innovative. In order to make representational sense, he must include the less ordinary components of the shared musical legacy. That renders his performance artistically engaging, as well as technically correct. In actual performances, innovation within the bounds of tradition can impress the diehard listeners and prompt them to indulge in judicious listening that in turn inspires the performer and shapes his or her improvised rendition. Known as *muḥāsabah*, or following carefully through a highly discriminating ear (Racy 1991:8), this participatory process symbolizes the musical and emotional bond between the artist and the listening initiates, or in a broader sense, his or her musical public. With this in mind, the Arab *taqāsīm* has been interpreted as a means of creating aesthetic sense through the application of common musical knowledge and uncommon artistic sensibility, or as “a perfect synthesis . . . between originality and tradition” (Elkholy 1978:17). In a similar vein, a study of sixteen *taqāsīm* performances in *maqām Nāhawand* (Nettl and Riddle 1973) indicates that freedom is usually displayed on the macrostructural level, with respect to performance length, sectional divisions, and modulations, but also significant adherence to the overall modal-compositional convention is shown, for example in such areas as ornaments, rhythmic motifs, and melodic sequences.

The Soaring Spirit

The other pole represents musical phenomena that transcend the realm of common practice. It embraces musical features that are novel, extraordinary, spontaneous, and contextually specific. Allowing for considerable freedom and individuality, this pole distinguishes performers from the rest of the community and enables them to express their own musical selves.

Such connotations are well-recognized by local musicians, theorists, and music critics. As one Egyptian scholar puts it, in the *taqāsīm*, “the imagination of the performing artist soars freely, according to his own mood, and his feeling of the ethos of the *maqām*” (Elkholy 1978:15). Similarly, Tawfīq al-Ṣabbāgh, a late virtuoso violinist and music theorist from Aleppo, Syria, describes the *taqāsīm* as the real measure of the musicians’ sense of creativity and imagination. As he explains, it is the litmus paper for testing their talent and ability to affect listeners emotionally. More significantly, he stresses that if the improvisation is less imaginative and less novel, in other words

less improvised, it loses a great deal of its emotional value (1950:140–41). The same premium on originality and spontaneity is expressed by the contemporary Syrian music theorist Maḥmūd ‘Ajjān, who maintains that “the taqāsīm must be created on the spur of the moment (*min waḥī al-khātir*) and extemporized by the performer following his own impulse” (1990:70). We are also told that through the taqāsīm, the artist “can express his own feeling and his inner emotional tribulations (*infi’ālāt*), which he derives from the depths of his own self, from the breadth of his musical knowledge, and from the ambiance surrounding his performance” (ibid.:70).

Meanwhile, the expression of individuality as such owes substantially to the freedom granted by the soloistic improvisatory idiom. To begin with, playing alone or merely against an accompanimental background gives the improvisor a high degree of compositional maneuverability. Furthermore, considerable flexibility is provided by the improvisatory style itself. Although on a finer level a taqāsīm has a highly patterned temporal structure, its relatively loose rhythmic parameter allows ample room for structural originality. Sometimes comparisons are made between improvising on an instrument against a metric ostinato, or *taqāsīm ‘alā al-waḥḍah*, a type of improvising that tends to reflect the general structure of the beat, and the regular, “loose” improvisation, or *taqāsīm fālītah*. Accordingly, although considered easier to play, the latter type opens the compositional boundaries more widely for the performer. It “takes away the restriction upon his imagination” (al-Ṣabbāgh 1950:142) and “offers a sense of release and freedom to the performer and the listener” (‘Ajjān 1990:74). At the same time, the former type, or the metrically accompanied taqāsīm is admired precisely because it poses a greater challenge to artists, who in turn must express themselves within a more temporally restrictive format. To add, the taqāsīm idiom gains further flexibility from being textually free as well as “tune” free, in other words being unbound by a fixed compositional design. Such flexibility enables the taqāsīm player to “derive inspiration from his inner consciousness,” to “respond to his own emotional tribulations,” and to “follow his own feeling and imagination” (al-Ṣabbāgh 1950:141; ‘Ajjān 1990:70, and others).

In this light, taqāsīm performers may be praised if their music is free of staple, or cliché components. Similarly, the creation of appropriate modal surprises for example in terms of modal shifts and cadential patterns is highly appreciated (see Touma 1976:35; Nelson 1982:42; Qūjamān 1978:87). Understandably, the incorporation of surprises is not always simple or safe. A surprise must be technically sound and emotionally moving, otherwise it becomes counterproductive and may adversely affect the musical performance.

The association between instrumental improvisation and individual creativity is often made when speaking of leading Arab instrumentalists. In

effect, the most celebrated performers are known for their distinctive styles of improvising, as well as for their grounding in the modal tradition. To cite some examples, the recorded taqāsīm of the late Egyptian violinist Aḥmad al-Ḥifnāwī, who performed in Umm Kulthūm's ensemble and was highly admired by listening connoisseurs, tend to: follow traditional modal progressions; maintain a stately pace conducive to *saṭṭanab*; give ample emphasis to the tonic and other central notes, at times through drone effects; and introduce modulations sparingly and to familiar modes, a phenomenon contributing to the ecstatic efficacy of the taqāsīm.⁴

In contrast, the taqāsīm of 'Abbūd 'Abd al-'Āl, a violinist from Lebanon, where in the 1960s he had led a popular instrumental ensemble that performed on television and in night-clubs, present both striking virtuosity and unpredictability. Trained in both the Western and Arab musical traditions, 'Abd al-'Āl introduces a plethora of accidental notes, "seductive" portamentos, melodic phrases that momentarily obscure the mode, and a strong feeling that the fulfillment of modal expectations is being constantly delayed or deferred. Displaying remarkable intonational precision, his performances, typically in the form of terse dance-music interludes, also show distinct dexterity and originality in the cadential patterns.⁵

Further examples are found in the recordings of the late Muḥammad 'Abd al-Karīm, a celebrated buzuq (long-necked lute) virtuoso from Syria. Viewed as an enigmatic genius, 'Abd al-Karīm, whose career was at its height during the 1940s and 1950s, is praised as a musician's musician. Making perfect modal sense, his taqāsīm introduce many clever musical innuendoes and appear intent on intriguing the intelligent listener. They often make subtle but effective turns that go against facile expectations. One of 'Abd al-Karīm's fortés, in addition to his impressive technique and profound modal knowledge, is his treatment of rhythm. Despite the overall nonmetric quality of the taqāsīm genre, his renditions incorporate complex rhythmic configurations, syncopations, delays, and anticipations, all created through skillful use of the plectrum. To add, his performances allow for seemingly endless variations on specific themes or melodic motifs, a striking compositional feature that reflects the artist's highly sophisticated rhythmic sense.⁶

Similarly impressive is the artistry of Ibrāhīm Salmān, an Iraqi-Jewish qānūn virtuoso well versed in both the Iraqi modal tradition and the prevalent East-Mediterranean modal practice. Salmān's style of playing the qānūn is lyrical and free-flowing, although by nature this zither-like instrument produces melodies through separate, plucked courses of strings. Salmān often uses the left hand for achieving correct and highly effective microtonal inflections and for adding subtle portamento effects, thus creating the impression that the notes are connected. Such an unusual ability to make

the qānūn “sing” renders Salmān’s taqāsīm highly ecstatic, as well as stylistically outstanding.⁷

Among ‘ūd players, there are numerous distinctive profiles. For example, the late Farīd al-Aṭraṣh of Egypt often prefaced his live vocal performances with his own taqāsīm on the ‘ūd. Displaying a popular style of ‘ūd playing seemingly intended to please large live audiences and fans, his renditions stand out for their relatively fast pacing and dense picking, and for making frequent use of the more familiar maqāmāt. Also striking is the prevalence of cliché *qafāt* and “expected surprises,” for example habitually ending his ‘ūd taqāsīm with a passage in maqām Kurd⁸ and gradually introducing a pedal-tone and a melodic configuration outlining the piece “Asturias” by the Spanish composer Albéniz. Al-Aṭraṣh’s taqāsīm are copied widely, at times note for note by amateur ‘ūd players, whose imitations often draw criticism for lacking originality, in other words for being banal and highly predictable.⁹

In contrast, the late Riyād al-Sunbāṭī of Egypt, considered one of the greatest composers and proponents of the Arab modal tradition, has recorded somewhat circumspect taqāsīm that flow along the organic structure of the mode but evoke intense ecstatic sensations. Particularly cherished by other musicians and musical aficionados, al-Sunbāṭī’s style is marked by precise intonation, careful pacing, distinct interest in resonance, careful utilization of pauses, economy and subtlety in the use of the plectrum, and full exploration of the primary mode before a modulation is introduced. His renditions achieve a unique balance between feeling and technical excellence.¹⁰

Meanwhile, the late Iraqi ‘ūd player Munīr Bashīr, whose style is influenced by the artistry of his Turkish trained teacher Sharīf Muḥyī al-Dīn Ḥaydar, presents a highly lyrical style which unlike the traditional mainstream of Arab ‘ūd playing appears seamless, thus avoiding clear cut *qafāt* and phrase delineations. Many of his (typically long) performances stay in the same maqām and maintain a subdued, meditative mood quite consistently. Listeners sometimes speak of non-Arab influences on his style, including North Indian ragas and jazz. Having performed in various major cities in Asia, Europe, and North America, Bashīr has created improvisatory works that are intended to evoke specific impressions, for example those of ancient Babylon. Deriving significantly from the Iraqi modal tradition, Bashīr’s style is also highly ambient. Employing subtle but effective dynamic inflections and a gradual build up in the intensity of picking, his playing is known to demand quiet concentration on the part of the listeners.¹¹

Instrumental improvisers tend to be fully conscious of their individuality, as well as their rootedness in the modal tradition. They occasionally articulate their premium on originality, or their being different from other

improvisers. For example, Bashīr, who was a music thinker and at one time a government administrator, viewed the solo improvisatory idiom as the perfect vehicle for expressing his own musical and philosophical ideas. As a matter of principle, he refrained from playing in the prevalent pan-Arab, Egyptian-oriented style usually expected of other 'ūd players, for example in Cairo, Beirut, and Damascus. For the same reason, he would not have performed popular, precomposed pieces, or "hits," by other composers, preferring instead to preserve his own identity and to be "himself."¹² The late Maṭar Muḥammad, a Lebanese buzuq player of a Gypsy background, went even further. As he explained, he tried to avoid hearing recordings by other instrumentalists so as not to find himself inadvertently imitating them.¹³

Improvising musicians may gain added individual recognition for reasons other than their innovative modal interpretations. For example, the public may correlate their distinguished musicianship with their distinctive social or ethnic backgrounds, or even physical traits. 'Abd al-Karīm's admirers often relate this artist's exceptional talent to his Gypsy background and even to his abnormally small physique. Furthermore, musicians become known for the unusual or innovative constructions of their musical instruments and for the novel ways in which they use such instruments. 'Abd al-Karīm explained that he adopted triple (instead of double) string-sets for both string courses on his buzuq, thus augmenting the resonance of the instrument and rendering the style of playing more stately.¹⁴ Comparably, Bashīr played a differently constructed 'ūd that used a loose (unglued) bridge, similar to that of a mandolin, a bridge that produced a sharper nodal edge against the strings and was intended to give the sound added definition. Characterized by higher string-tension and brighter timbre, Bashīr's instrument also had an additional low-pitched single string oddly but conveniently placed on the bottom (or below the high-pitched end of the string set) and used mainly as an occasional drone. Obviously, such innovative endeavors owed a great deal to instrument makers' creative interactions with practicing artists.¹⁵

Conclusion

This study has illustrated music's tendency to embrace a wide variety of aesthetic, social, and ideological meanings. Along comparable lines, cultural anthropologists and ethnomusicologists have demonstrated that human expressions can be construed in remarkably different ways. For example, it is shown that political symbols as such are often less obviously political, or are even intrinsically nonpolitical (Cohen 1979), and similarly, a sacred Indian Tamil poem is believed to embrace typical ambigu-

ities intended to evoke worldviews that are quite contrastive (Teawick 1988). Meanwhile, a study of Paul Simon's collaborative work *Graceland* has indicated that music as a polysemic expression can provoke opposing social, political, and artistic interpretations (Meintjes 1990). In this article I have pointed out that musical improvisation as represented by the Arab taqāsīm is capable of shifting between zones of significance that are complementary or even oppositional.

In terms of its ability to alternate between different realms of significance, depending on the viewer's mode of perception, the Arab taqāsīm tends to operate like what psychologists call an "ambiguous figure" (Statt 1981:6, 84). This term refers to certain types of pictorial designs, for example a composite that enables the viewer to see either two facial profiles in silhouette form facing each other or an intervening white space in the shape of a vase. Another familiar example is the outline drawing of a cube whose three dimensional configuration may shift spatially as we glance at it. As an ambiguous musical symbol, the taqāsīm is equipped to connote a wide variety of complementary cultural and artistic poles such as: community-individuality; norm-idiosyncrasy; restriction-freedom; expectancy-surprise; reason-intuition; knowledge-talent; theory-practice; and other binary sets (see Figure 1) that I have referred to collectively and metaphorically as the "home-base" and the "soaring spirit" complexes.

Obviously, the varying connotations of the taqāsīm genre cannot be isolated from the tensions that pervade Arab culture as a whole. Throughout history, improvisation has been cherished, as well as imbued with spir-

Figure 1. Symbolic Poles of the Taqāsīm.

Community —————	————— Individuality
Norm —————	————— Idiosyncrasy
Restriction —————	————— Freedom
Tradition —————	————— Innovation
Expectancy —————	————— Surprise
Consciousness —————	————— Ineffability
Reason —————	————— Intuition
Consistency —————	————— Diversity
Workmanship —————	————— Inspiration
Theory —————	————— Practice
Knowledge —————	————— Talent
Correctness —————	————— Affect
Mind —————	————— Spirit
Precalculation —————	————— Spontaneity
Ethos —————	————— Pathos

itual significance, a phenomenon that culminates in the art of Qur'anic chanting. However, purely instrumental music has aroused certain ambivalence among the morally-minded, and similarly has played a relatively small role in the local Arab Sufi practice, which has influenced the artistry of many highly celebrated singers.¹⁶ Meanwhile, because the taqāsīm and related improvisatory genres have been closely identified with the indigenous artistic image, they have become particularly vulnerable to the endemic forces of westernization and modernization. As emblems of the local, the old, and the conventional facets of Arab music, they have acquired a precarious position, and at times have been subjected to the negative rhetoric of Western-minded composers and music thinkers. In addition, the rise of an Arab mass audience and the overwhelming popularity of other nonimprovisational categories of composition have contributed to the growth of a large segment of listeners who have little understanding of or appreciation for improvised music. Fewer young performers seem interested in or capable of improvising very well.

Furthermore, in view of recent postmodern trends, the taqāsīm genre appears increasingly transformed in terms of both structure and symbolic content. As presented through technological media, modal improvisations are often fragmented, as well as removed from their conventional listening contexts. Typically, radio and television shows use taqāsīm "snippets" to fill program gaps or to create ambient backdrops for poetry recitations. Also, some pastiche-like musical compositions juxtapose short modal improvisations with other historically unrelated components, in one specific case, with the opening theme from Mozart's Symphony Number 40 in G minor.¹⁷ In the music of Lebanese composer Ziyād Raḥbānī, short taqāsīm with acted out ecstatic exclamations are intended to parody the traditional mannerisms of listening to Arab music. Lately, modal improvisations have been rendered on microtonally adjusted keyboard instruments, on the saxophone, and on a number of indigenous folk instruments such as the Egyptian rabābah (spike-fiddle).

Such patterns of generic crossing and recontextualization are likely to create new symbolic reconfigurations, and fadeouts. For example, the underlying connotations of "tradition," "locality," "identity," "norm," and "community" will probably become less obvious or clear cut. Similarly, the relationships between the various complementary poles, including those spanning such areas as "convention" and "innovation," might lose some fluidity and directionality. The ambiguous figures may either grow less operative as such, or in some cases develop further layers of ambiguity. Particularly, as the taqāsīm idiom gains appeal among world music connoisseurs and appears in certain jazz, "fusion," and experimental musical contexts, added nuances of globalization could emerge.

To sum up, in the Arab world today the connotations of improvising are closely linked to the dominant cultural and artistic worldviews. The significance and content of improvised instrumental music reflect the interplay of such opposing tendencies as the interest in local identity and the preservation of traditional values on the one hand, and the strong urge to change and to accommodate global musical developments on the other. Nonetheless, the art of taqāsīm maintains an unmistakable position in contemporary Arab music. Representing a centuries-old practice, it also retains a special mystique as an artistic expression. Its role as such is intimately linked to its symbolic versatility, its profile as a multifaceted icon.

Notes

1. This anecdote appears in the writings of the tenth century group of Muslim philosophers Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' (Godwin 1987:70–71). It is also recounted by Habib H. Tuma (1976:33).

2. The literal meaning of taqāsīm is "division." The association between instrumental improvisation and division is somewhat vague, and open to speculation. Furthermore, "improvisation" as a musical concept does not have an exact equivalent in Arabic. The general term *irtijāl* tends to have the negative connotations of being impromptu, unprepared, spontaneous, and on the spur of the moment. Incidentally, the plural form, taqāsīm, is more prevalently used to indicate instrumental improvisation as a musical genre, although the singular form, taqāsīm, is occasionally used to mean either a single instrumental improvisation or instrumental improvising in general. Similarly, an individual performance can be referred to as a *taqsimah*, or "an instrumental improvisation." For further information on the early use and conceptualization of this genre in Ottoman Turkey see Walter Feldman's probing historical study (1993).

3. For a detailed description of these two formats, especially the Egyptian, see Racy 1983.

4. A few of al-Hifnāwī's performances other than the short solos heard in Umm Kulthūm's songs have been released on cassette tapes. Some of his best performances appeared some twenty years ago on a cassette titled: *Sabrah ma' 'Azīf al-Kamān al-Awwal al-Ustādh Aḥmad al-Hifnāwī* (An Evening Performance with the Foremost Violinist, Master Artist Ahmad al-Hifnawi), Ṣawt al-Qāhirah, Sono Cairo, 76094/401. (Sono Cairo, P.O. Box 2017 Telex No. 93364 SONEC UN Cairo, Egypt).

5. Some of 'Abd al-Āl's best performances appeared on LPs during the 1970s with his orchestra, Firqat al-Awtār al-Dhahabiyyah (The Golden-Strings Ensemble) and were conceived to a large extent as nightclub dance, or "bellydance" music. One such album is titled: *Layālī al-'Arab* (Nights of the Arabs); *Belly Dance for Arabian Nights*, Abbud Abdel Aal & his Golden Strings, Peters International PILPS-10046, 1973 S.L.D. Lebanon; Recorded in Lebanon—manufactured in USA by P.I. Records, Inc. 275 West 39th Street, New York, NY 10018. Another album, specifically one disc side and half of the other side, featured the artist and his ensemble: *Alwān min al-Sharq* (Colors from the East); *The Exotic Orient in the Flesh: Ṣawt al-Nujūm* (Voice of Stars), V05 10 007 A; Recorded at Uniart Studios, Beirut, 1971, distributed in Europe and Africa by Sono Disc, B.P. 222-18-Paris, Tel. 255-46075.

6. 'Abd al-Karīm's performances, which at one time were broadcast weekly from Radio Damascus are generally difficult to find. One short excerpt in maqām 'Ajam recorded in Damascus in 1960 appears on an LP titled *The Living Tradition: The Syrian maqām*; Recordings, photograph, and text by Deben Bhattacharya, Argo, 2FB68; The Decca Records Company Limited, Argo Division, 115 Fulham Road, London, SW3 GRR. I have also heard his music on a less current cassette release, which apparently was dubbed and distributed by Syriana Arab Music & Video, B1217 Redondo Bch., CA 90278-1217, (213-644-0980, 542-0150-USA).

However, his listening fans usually own many of his recordings, mostly cassette copies of original radio broadcasts or performances at private gatherings. 'Abd al-Karīm was born in 1905 and died in 1989.

7. Salmān's recordings have limited accessibility in the West, although some researchers and music connoisseurs own noncommercial recordings of his music. A short sample of his playing appears on the cassette *Simon Shabeen: The Music of Mobamed Abdel Wahab*; Axiom 539 865-4, distributed by Island Records Inc., 14 4th St. NY, NY 10012, 1990, also available on CD. Moreover a full CD of his music, essentially a selection from different performances, is titled: *Abraham Salman: Saltana*. Nada Productions, PO Box 45436, Haifa, Israel.

8. Resembling a Phrygian mode and displaying a typical descending quality, Kurd employs the following notes in relative pitch: C', B-flat, A-flat, G, F, E-flat, D-flat, C.

9. Such taqāsīm preludes and at times interludes within al-Aṭraṣh's songs, can be heard on a variety of this artist's cassettes and CD recordings, many available in the United States. Also a collection of his taqāsīm has appeared on the cassette: *Farid El Atrache: An Evening with the King of the Oud; Takassim Oud*, EMI 03TC-VLMC 103; Voice of Lebanon, Produced by Robert Khayat & Co. P.O. Box 11-150, Beirut, Lebanon, 1980. Farid al-Aṭraṣh was born in 1915 and died in 1974.

10. Al-Sunbātī's taqāsīm have appeared on a few releases including a recent CD titled: *Rityād al Sunbātī: Taqāsīm 'ūd*, produced by Sawt al-Qāhirah, Manufactured and distributed by SIDI, P.O. Box 13241, Jeddah 21483, Saudi Arabia, Tel. 6623332, Fax 6827091. Al-Sunbātī was born in 1906 and died in 1981.

11. Bashīr's recordings are quite accessible today. Having been widely distributed on various labels in LP and CD forms, they can be obtained in major record stores in the West. Many are recordings of live performances. Two of his recent releases are: *INEDIT, Munir Bachir: Meditation*, recorded in Amman Jordan in 1995; Maison des Cultures du Monde, France, Released 1996, Compact disc, W 260071; and *Recital Munir Bachir: Solos de Luth-Oud*, Club du Disque Arabe, Paris Compact Disc AAA 003, CDA 401, a CD that also features another major artist, the late Egyptian composer and 'ūd player Muḥammad al-Qaṣabjī.

12. From personal conversations I had with Munir Bashīr in Baghdad and in the United States mostly during the late 1980s. Mr. Bashīr died in September 1997.

13. From a personal conversation I had with Maṭar Muḥammad in Beirut in 1970. Muḥammad died in 1995.

14. From a radio interview with 'Abd al-Karīm, probably from Radio Damascus, I heard in the summer of 1988. Cassette copies of this interview are owned by some of the artist's fans.

15. Examples of major instrument makers have been the late Fāḍil 'Awwād, an 'ūd maker from Baghdad who usually made Bashīr's 'ūds, the late Jamīl Jūrjī and his son, both 'ūd makers from Cairo, and the several generations of the Naḥḥāt family, who made 'ūds in Damascus, Syria.

16. In local Sufi practice, the reed-flute may appear in certain folk-oriented *dbikr* performances, for example in Egypt. Also nāy taqāsīm can be heard at the Mawlawiyyah (Mevlevi) ritual in Aleppo, Syria along with other instruments, particularly the small kettle-drums and large cymbals.

17. From an album titled *Mozart in Egypt*, Virgin Records, France, an excerpt of which was broadcast from KCRW, Santa Monica Radio, in March 1998, on a program titled Café L.A. and hosted by Tom Schnabel.

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